his book *Don't Disturb the Dead*, about the family whose surname will forever be synonymous with horror, notes that Shyam Ramsay was inclined towards horror and the older Tulsi to comedy, music and other aspects. "Otherwise, things become very dry without breaks," Shyam tells Dasgupta in the book. Think the *Sholay* parody sequence in *Purana Mandir* featuring Lalita Pawar and Jagdeep, or Satish Shah playing a Hitchcock-worshipping horror film director seeking inspiration in *Veerana*. But Ramsay films weren't exactly horcoms. The earliest known such film in Hindi was *Bhoot Bangla* (1965), directed by the ace comedian Mehmood.



> **"I TREAT HORROR AS A FANTASY WORLD. BODIES COMING OUT OF THE GRAVE, *EK MAHAL MEIN KOI AKELA* [SOMEBODY ALONE IN A MANSION]... THAT'S NOT MY SCENE..."**
>
> **— AMAR KAUSHIK**
> ***Filmmaker***

Bhoot Bangla, though, was an exception rather than the rule. Horror itself was hard to find until the Ramsays made it their trade. It's a striking absence given that horror has a long career in Hollywood, with many subgenres—psychological, gory, slasher flicks, creature, zombie and vampire, body possession, home invasion, even spoofs. Why, you even have a season for dedicated releases—Halloween—when titles drop by the dozen, in theatres and on streaming channels. Ram Gopal Varma did evoke a sense of genuine dread in the '90s and 2000s with films like *Raat*, *Kaun*, *Bhoot* and *Phoonk*, as did the Bhatts with the *Raaz* franchise. Still, the general consensus was that scary films don't put bums on seats, especially as many are rated adults-only. That may have changed in 2024. Jio Studios' *Shaitaan* was the first horror flick to enter the Rs 100 crore club. It had black magic, body possession, horror, and star billing in Ajay Devgn and R. Madhavan. The latter plays an evil sorcerer from whom the Devgn character is trying to save his daughter.

The current spate of horcoms is cleverly subverting the genre's tropes. So, a damsel could be in distress but she is also capable of fighting her own battle (*Roohi*). Mithuraaj Dhusiya, who has written a PhD thesis on the subject as well as a book, *Indian Horror Cinema: (En)gendering the Monstrous*, says, "Horror comedies disrupt the male heteronormative discourses found in mainstream non-horror films and discuss non-normative things which make them more progressive and powerful". Among the many zingers in *Stree 2* is the one Banerjee ad-libs—"*Bhediya ban, Animal nahin*", a dig at Ranbir Kapoor's hypermasculine blockbuster. An associate professor of English at Hansraj College, Dhusiya also brings up the wolf who safeguards the forest, played by Kriti Sanon in *Bhediya* and *Munjya*, cleverly raising the issue of consent as the restless spirit of a boy desires a woman who is not interested in him. "The Hindi film industry thrives on the lover chasing the girl, but *Munjya* goes away from the monomaniac, adolescent masculinity and obsessive love to a slightly censored love where, in the end, you accept that boys and girls can also be friends," says Dhusiya.

THE REGIONAL FLAVOUR

If there's one place horcoms have thrived, it's in regional cinema. The Tamil film industry has its own horcom franchise in Raghava Lawrence's Muni series which so far has resulted in four films. But nobody loves horcoms as much as the Bengalis do. *Ajab Gayer Ajab Katha* (1998), *Bhooter Bhabishyat* (2012), *Jekhane Bhooter Bhoy* (2012), *Goynar Baksho* (2013), *Chhayamoy* (2013), *Bhabishyater Bhoot* (2019) and *Ballavpurer Roopkatha* (2022) are just some of the popular ones.

A fan of Marathi horcoms *Zapatlela*, *Pachhadlela* and *Bhutacha Bhau*, Sarpotdar made hit Marathi films like *Mauli* and *Faster Fene* but the one that gave him cult status and earned him the opportunity to direct *Munjya* was *Zombivli* (2022), a Marathi horcom featuring zombies in Dombivli, a city on the outskirts of Mumbai. His family, Sarpotdar adds, is unable to make